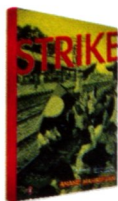


Train to Chennai

MGR makes a guest appearance in this first novel steeped in nostalgia

| By Geeta Doctor |



THE STRIKE

by ANAND
MAHADEVAN
Penguin
Price: Rs 299
Pages: 272

The children of diasporic Indians in North America are not just adept at maxing the score in spelling bees and maths Olympiads, they are pandering to the taste for what publishers must call Thatha-Paati tales, or remembrance of roots severed in the great Indian subcontinent. Depending on which part of the country the writer might belong, the nomenclature for the granddads and grannies might change. Ved Mehta obviously set the trend with tales of his Chachaji. As a rule, the genre includes showing off about the family house, a wise old Granddad or Grandmum, randy uncles and aunts, food, holidays, railway journeys and servants. One would even go so far to say that the formula is one that served the displaced returnees of the Raj era as they sat dreaming of their ayahs and khan-

samahs in Bath or Leicester.

Anand Mahadevan is based in Toronto. His first book brings a South Indian flavour to many of these elements though he then adds a twist to the tale by setting it within a real historical event, the death of MGR and the backlash of hysteria that followed. We see the events through the perspective of Hari, a young boy on the cusp of adolescence, whose passion is trainspotting. Indeed the first sentence should serve as a warning: "Hari's original plan was only to pee on the tracks." For it's leaky memories all the way.

Mahadevan has obviously been told that the great secret of the writer's art, or more specifically the playwright's duty, is that if you show a gun in the first act, you've got to make sure that it goes off in the last one. The smoking gun here is Hari's fascination to climb into an engine's driver's cabin. There's enough rambling on about the Great Indian Railway bizarre to earn Mahadevan a lifetime pass from the Indian Railways and these are actually the best bits. His intentions are however much more serious, a breakdown of services or "strike" as the title suggests just as the train is chugging into Ennore Station, (a suburb of Chennai) on the fateful day of MGR's death. It then becomes a thriller or an "I know what happened the Summer that MGR died" kind of expose.

The author just might have succeeded in his efforts if he did not keep pulling the chain and stopping so often to give us touristy tidbits on what's what in Tamil Nadu. There are so many characters like the talkative *hijra*, Radha, the North Indian woman with her nubile daughter, the chain snatcher, the servant woman Sivagami and her ne'er-do-well son Vishu, besides the usual cast of uncles and aunties that it reads like a sit-com. There's also a wanker in a train toilet sequence which makes one wonder whether Mahadevan is trying for the bad sex prize, juvenile department. It's meant to be a Hurrah Hari moment that Mahadevan recounts with the same obsessive detail that he devotes to his trains. There's a good sequence involving the serving and eating of Chakkara Pongal, the sweet rice dish of Tamil Nadu, towards the end. So all is not lost.



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SAURABH SINGH